

Gelsemium sempervirens (Loganiaceae) Yellow Jasmine, Gelsemium

Description Evergreen woody climber growing to 20 ft (6 m). Has shiny, dark green leaves and clusters of fragrant, trumpet-shaped yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the southern U.S. and Central America, yellow jasmine prefers damp sites. The rootstock is unearthed in autumn.

Part Used Rootstock.

Constituents Yellow jasmine contains indole alkaloids (including gelsemine and gelsedine), iridoids, coumarins, and tannins. The alkaloids are toxic and act as a depressant to the central nervous system.

History & Folklore It is unclear whether yellow jasmine was used in Native American medicine. The plant came into regular use only in the middle of the 19th century. It was first employed by followers of the Eclectic herbal movement, and then later became an official medicine, listed in the *Pharmacopoeia of the United States* from 1863 to 1926.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A potent medicinal herb, yellow jasmine is prescribed in small doses as a sedative and antispasmodic, most commonly for neuralgia (pain caused by nerve irritation or damage). Yellow jasmine is often given for nerve pain affecting the face. The herb is also applied externally to treat intercostal neuralgia (nerve pain between the ribs) and sciatica (pain resulting from pressure on a nerve in the lower spine). Yellow jasmine's antispasmodic property is used in treating whooping cough and asthma. The herb is occasionally taken for migraine, insomnia, and bowel problems, and also to reduce blood pressure. Yellow jasmine is also used in homeopathic medicine.

⚠️ Cautions Yellow jasmine is an extremely toxic plant that should be used only under professional supervision. The plant is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.



Dried rootstock

Geranium maculatum (Geraniaceae) Wild Geranium

Description Perennial growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has deeply cleft leaves, pink-purple flowers, and beak-shaped fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to woodlands of eastern and central North America, the root is dug up in early spring, and the aerial parts are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Root, aerial parts.

Constituents Wild geranium contains up to 30% tannins.

History & Folklore Native American peoples used wild geranium for sore throats, mouth ulcers, infected gums, and oral thrush. The herb was later used by European settlers for diarrhea, internal bleeding, cholera, and venereal diseases.

Medicinal Actions & Uses An astringent and clotting agent, wild geranium is used today much as in earlier times. The herb is often prescribed for irritable bowel syndrome and hemorrhoids, and it is used to staunch wounds. It may also be used to treat heavy menstrual bleeding and excessive vaginal discharge.

Related Species See herb robert (*G. robertianum*, following entry).

Caution Wild geranium should only be taken for a few weeks at a time.

Geranium robertianum (Geraniaceae) Herb Robert

Description Strong-smelling annual or biennial herb growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has deeply cleft red-green leaves, bright pink flowers, and pointed seed capsules.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and Asia, herb robert is naturalized in North America. It is gathered in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts, root.

Constituents Herb robert contains tannins, a bitter principle (geraniin), traces of volatile oil, and citric acid.

History & Folklore Herb robert's unpleasant odor has earned it the name "stinking Bob" in parts of England.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Herb robert is little used in contemporary European herbal medicine. It is occasionally employed in much the same way as Wild geranium (*G. maculatum*, preceding entry), as an astringent and wound healer. The herb bears closer investigation as a remedy. According to one authority it is effective against stomach ulcers and inflammation of the uterus, and it holds some potential as a treatment for cancer.

Geum urbanum (Rosaceae) Avens

Description Downy perennial growing to 60 cm (2 ft). Has wiry stems, compound leaves, small, yellow 5-petaled flowers, and fruit covered with hooks.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and central Asia, avens is a common wayside plant. The root is dug up in spring, and the aerial parts are picked in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts, root.

Constituents Avens contains phenolic glycosides (including eugenol), tannins, a volatile oil, and possibly a sesquiterpene lactone (cnicin).

History & Folklore Once known as *herba benedicta* (blessed herb), avens was credited with significant magical powers in the Middle Ages. A German text of 1493 states that if avens root is in the house, the devil is powerless. According to tradition, the root should be unearthed on March 25th.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Avens is an astringent herb, used principally for problems affecting the mouth, throat, and gastrointestinal tract. The herb tightens up soft gums, heals mouth ulcers, makes a good gargle for infections of the pharynx and larynx, and reduces irritation of the stomach and gut. It may be taken for peptic ulcers, irritable bowel syndrome, diarrhea, and dysentery. Avens has been used in a lotion or ointment as a soothing remedy for hemorrhoids. The herb may also be used as a douche for treating excessive vaginal discharge. Avens reputedly has a mild quinine-type action in lowering fever.

Glechoma hederacea syn. Nepeta glechoma (Lamiaceae) Ground Ivy, Alehoof

Description Creeping perennial herb growing to 15 cm (6 in). Has long rooting runners, notched kidney-shaped leaves, and purple-blue flowers in whorls.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and western Asia, ground ivy is now naturalized in other temperate regions, including North America. It thrives on the outskirts of woods and alongside paths and hedges. It is gathered in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Ground ivy contains sesquiterpenes, flavonoids, a volatile oil, a bitter principle (glechomine), caffeic acids, and tannins.

History & Folklore Known in parts of England as "alehoof," ground ivy was used to flavor and clarify ale, the traditional drink of the Anglo-Saxons. In Medieval times, it was recommended for fever, and was a popular treatment for chronic coughs. The 16th-century herbalist John Gerard considered it a valuable remedy for tinnitus.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Ground ivy is tonic, diuretic, and decongestant, and is used to treat many problems involving the mucous